these restrictions have been eliminated. The Voting Rights Act of 1965, which eliminated literacy restrictions and poll taxes, was the last major reform to expand political participation in the United States by ending the disenfranchisement of African Americans in the South.

Most analysts agree that without some basic protections guaranteed to individuals and organizations, democracy has little meaning. Freedom of speech and organization, and freedom from arbitrary arrest, for example, are considered key democratic rights. When opposition figures are jailed or murdered, an election is not considered very democratic.

Still, most democratic countries place some kind of restrictions on these political freedoms. No government allows groups to try to overthrow it. In the United States, Alien and Sedition Acts of 1798, the Sedition Act of 1918, the Smith Act of 1940 and the PATRIOT Act of 2001 are examples of how the U.S. government has tried to strengthen its ability to prosecute actual or potential challenges to its authority or existence, especially when national security is threatened.

Finally, political systems can vary in terms of what spheres are subject to democratic controls. This is where capitalist and socialist systems can diverge significantly. Socialism argues that economic decisions should be made by the government; capitalism is based on the idea that economic decisions should be made by private individuals and institutions. In a democracy, socialism could be more democratic, because democratic institutions can make decisions about the economy. If a government is undemocratic, though, leaving the economy in private hands at least offers a potential counterweight to the government.

Cuba in the 1970s: How it Worked

Closer ties to the USSR, and a system of economic planning based on the Soviet model, characterized the 1970s. Cuba joined the COMECON in 1972, and implemented its first Five-Year Plan in 1975. Politically too, the Cuban government reorganized itself on the Soviet model. The Cuban Communist Party (*Partido Comunista de Cuba*, or PCC) held its first Congress in 1975, and in 1976 Cuba's government approved a new, socialist Constitution. The Constitution established a system of *Poder*